

Lab: Market Sensing Design Workshop

Objective

Design a comprehensive market sensing strategy for your invention using Active Inference perception principles. You will practice structuring customer discovery conversations for maximum precision, analyzing competitive signals, and building a trend detection framework — all treating market research as active inference about your ecosystem.

Materials and Prerequisites

- Your invention concept and ecosystem map from Modules 01-02
- Access to web search for basic competitive and market research
- Familiarity with Bayesian updating concepts

Part 1: Prediction-First Research Design (15 minutes)

Active Inference perception begins with predictions, not data collection. Before seeking evidence, you must articulate what your model predicts.

Step 1: State your invention and its target market.

Write your response here

Step 2: Write five specific, falsifiable predictions your generative model makes about the market. Each prediction should be concrete enough that you could identify a clear prediction error.

#	Prediction	What evidence would confirm it?	What evidence would disconfirm it?	Current confidence (1-10)
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

Step 3: Rank your predictions by strategic importance. Which prediction, if wrong, would most fundamentally change your approach?

Write your response here

Part 2: Customer Discovery Conversation Design (15 minutes)

Design a customer discovery interview using the Active Inference approach: seek prediction errors, not confirmation.

Step 1: Define your target interviewee. Who would provide the highest-precision evidence about your most important prediction?

Write your response here

Step 2: Draft five interview questions following the "Mom Test" principles (ask about past behavior, not future intentions; ask about specific instances, not general attitudes; ask about commitments, not opinions).

#	Question	What prediction does this test?	What would a confirming answer look like?	What would a disconfirming answer look like?
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				

Step 3: What follow-up questions would you ask if the customer's response generates a significant prediction error? How would you explore the error rather than explain it away?

Write your response here

Step 4: Evaluate the precision profile of your interview design. Rate each question on two dimensions:

Question #	Specificity (1-5)	Generalizability (1-5)	Net Precision Assessment
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Part 3: Competitive Intelligence Analysis (10 minutes)

Practice inferring competitor models from observable actions.

Step 1: Choose one real competitor (or potential competitor) for your invention. List five observable actions they have taken in the past year (product launches, hires, patents, partnerships, pricing changes, public statements).

#	Observable Action	Date/Timeframe	Source
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Step 2: For each action, infer what it reveals about the competitor's generative model — their beliefs about the market, their predictions about the future, and their assessment of threats.

Action #	What it reveals about their market beliefs	What it reveals about their future predictions	What it reveals about their threat assessment
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			

Step 3: Based on this analysis, predict the competitor's most likely next move. What would they need to observe to change course?

Write your response here

Part 4: Trend Detection Exercise (10 minutes)

Practice distinguishing signal from noise in innovation-relevant trends.

Step 1: Identify three trends potentially relevant to your invention.

Trend	Domain	Evidence For (signals)	Evidence Against (noise indicators)	Convergence with other trends?
1				
2				
3				

Step 2: For each trend, estimate where it falls on a Gartner-style trajectory: (a) Rising hype, (b) Peak hype, (c) Trough of disillusionment, (d) Climbing toward productivity, (e) Productive maturity.

Write your response here

Step 3: How does each trend's trajectory affect your invention's timing? Should you accelerate, wait, or pivot based on trend positioning?

Write your response here

Part 5: Sensing Portfolio Design (10 minutes)

Combine your work into an integrated market sensing strategy.

Step 1: Design a sensing portfolio — a set of ongoing and periodic sensing activities that will keep your model updated.

Sensing Activity	Frequency	Evidence Type	Precision Level	Cost/ Effort	Primary Prediction Tested

Step 2: What is the biggest blind spot in your sensing portfolio? What important aspect of your ecosystem is not being adequately sensed?

Write your response here

Step 3: Design one new sensing activity specifically to address that blind spot. What would it involve, and how would you interpret its results?

Write your response here

Discussion and Debrief

1. How did the prediction-first approach change your research design compared to starting with "What do I need to know?"
2. Which of your predictions do you feel least confident about? What sensing activity would most efficiently reduce that uncertainty?
3. How did reverse-engineering your competitor's model from their actions change your understanding of the competitive landscape?
4. What was the most surprising insight from the trend detection exercise? Did any trends turn out to be more noise than signal upon closer analysis?
5. How would you adapt your sensing portfolio as your invention moves from concept to prototype to launch? What new sensing activities become necessary at each stage?